

W H A L E C L A S S

Circle Time Guide

Everything you need, one page per day

Animal Habitats

Week 28

Week of Apr 6–9

13 minutes a day

ages 2.5–6

English learners





Week 28 · Week Overview

Animal Habitats
Print · laminate · ring-bind · hold this all week

5 words they'll own by Friday →

nest

den

pond

web

live

🐼 A FOUR-day week — the Qingming Festival falls on Monday 5 April, so we run Tuesday to Friday. Tuesday carries two homes; the song has four verses; Friday is untouched.

Little's (2.5–3)

One word + a gesture is a win: **"Nest!"** (hands cupped into a bowl), **"Pond!"** (one hand swims like a fish), **"Web!"** (ten fingers spread wide).

Bigs (4–6)

Sentence frames: **"The bird lives in a nest."**

"The fish lives in the pond."

"Where do you live?"

The week at a glance

MON	No class — Qingming Festival	Nothing to grab. School is closed for Qingming Festival and we start the new theme on Tuesday 6 April
TUE	Nest and Den	a real bird's nest in the Magic Box (or one you build from twigs and moss the night before); a...
WED	The Jar Pond	a jar pond in the Magic Box
THU	A Silky Web	a wool web in the Magic Box
FRI	Where Do You Live? + Big Review	everything from the week packed back into the box

2 MIN

📦 Magic Box hook



4 MIN

📢 Teach the words



3 MIN

🎵 Song · today's verse



3 MIN

⚡ Game · move it



1 MIN

🗯️ Whisper-shout close

Weekly rituals — use these every single day

Attention grabber: Teacher: "One, two, three — eyes on me!" · Kids: "One, two — eyes on you!"

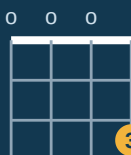
The Magic Box: any box with a lid. Chant it, shake it, sniff it, peek dramatically — the day's key prop lives inside.

The two-tier rule: never make a little produce a sentence, and never let a big get away with one word.

Whisper → shout close: calms them down, then releases them — every single closing.

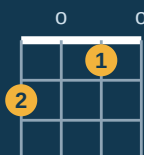
Teacher-fails-on-purpose: once a day, get it wrong and let them correct you — the correction shout is the loudest language of the day.

One song a week: same chorus at every circle, one new verse each morning, the whole song on Friday.



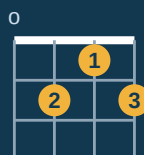
G C E A

C



G C E A

F



G C E A

G7

Uke quick-ref

Strum: Down · Down · Down-Up ("where — do — you-live"). Can't manage it yet? Four slow downs per bar works fine — it is a question-and-answer song and the children are listening to the question.

The song needs only C · F · G7.

MONDAY

No class — Qingming Festival

There is no circle time today. This week is **four days**: Tuesday 6 to Friday 9 April.

Nothing to grab. School is closed for **Qingming Festival** and we start the new theme on **Tuesday 6 April** — with a real bird's nest, first thing out of the Magic Box.

WHY THE SHORT WEEK

Qingming falls on the Monday, so the week starts a day late and every day after it does a little more:

OUTDOORS WHAT TO LOOK AT OVER THE LONG WEEKEND

Qingming is the day families sweep the graves and then walk out into the green — **a spring walk**, treading the new grass. Everything this week is out there today, for free. Tell the parents on Friday afternoon:

If your Monday does run (a make-up day, or a class that is in): don't start the theme. Go outside and do the looking. Then Tuesday opens exactly as written and they arrive already full of it.

NEXT COMING BACK

We start on **Tuesday 6 April** with **Animal Habitats**. First circle back: the box is heavier than it looks and smells faintly of the outside, and inside it is a **real bird's nest**. Every child holds it with two hands before a single word is taught.

TUESDAY

Nest and Den

Today's words: **nest** and **den** (two homes today — this is the four-day week)

Grab: a **real bird's nest** in the Magic Box (or one you build from twigs and moss the night before); a **shoebox den** with a flap for a door and a little **fox** tucked inside it; five small eggs (wooden, or stones wrapped in wool) hidden round the room **before** the children come in; the nest and burrow cards; the picture cards from print pack page 11.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today the box is light and it smells faintly of outside. Hold it up. Whole class chants:

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Shake it — a dry little rustle, nothing solid. Lift the lid a crack and **sniff**, loudly, eyes shut. Sniff again. Let your face go amazed.

TEACHER "Something in here is made of **sticks**... and **grass**... and somebody **lived** in it." (*lift the nest out on two flat palms, very slowly, and hold it at their eye level*)

The nest goes right round the circle on two hands and every child holds it. Hands cupped into a bowl: **"Nest!"**

Say it once, plainly: nobody is at home in this nest, which is why we may hold it. A nest with eggs in it is looked at from far away and never touched.

4 MIN TEACH · NEST, THEN DEN

Everybody makes a nest with their own two hands. We say it twice — small and slow, then big:

Twigs and moss and a bit of my hair, (*cup both hands into a bowl*)

Round and round till the nest is **there**. (*turn the cupped hands round and round*)

Up in the tree, where the wind can blow — (*lift the nest hands right up high and sway*)

That's where the **bird** lives. Now you know! (*one finger points at the real nest*)

Then the second thing. The box is not empty — there is a flap in the side of a shoebox and the room goes quiet while you open it. Inside, curled up, a fox.

TEACHER "The bird's home is **high** and **open**. The fox's home is **low**... and **dark**... and it is called a **den**." (*both hands make a low arch on the floor and everybody peeps into it*)

LITTLES do the two gestures and the two words: **"Nest!" "Den!"** **BIGS** owe you the frame: **"The bird lives in a nest." "The fox lives in a den."**

Teacher fails: try to put the **fox** into the **nest**. Push. Wedge him in. Stand back, delighted with yourself. Wait. They will take him off you and put him back where he belongs, and they will tell you why.

Chinese moment: lay the **nest** card beside the nest and the **burrow** card beside the den, and say **bird's nest** and **fox's den** once each. Leave both cards out; the row grows by one card a day and stands finished on Friday.

3 MIN GAME · NEST HUNT

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" The empty nest sits in the middle of the mat. Five eggs are hidden round the room, two of them in plain sight at knee height for the littlest ones.

TEACHER "The eggs have rolled **out** of the nest! **Walking** feet... find **one** egg... and carry it home." (*two hands, held against the chest, all the way back*)

One egg per child, carried in two hands and laid in the nest — not dropped. **LITTLES** say **"Nest!"** as they lay it down; **BIGS** give the sentence:

"The egg lives in the nest." Count them into the nest out loud together: one, two, three, four, five.

Then, with the last two minutes, **animal-home charades:** you call a home, they do the way in. **Den** — crawl in low. **Nest** — fly up and land. **Pond** — swim down. (Pond is tomorrow; let them meet the word here first.)

Five eggs, five and no more — the nest on the shelf tray is built to hold exactly five, and that is its control of error all week.

1 MIN CLOSE

Everybody's hands cupped into a nest. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Where do you live? — HOME!" (*open hands questioning · cup the ear · both arms thrown wide into a roof on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *A Nest Is Noisy* (Dianna Hutts Aston) — page after page of nests that are nothing like each other. Or just take the nest to the window and look for the real one outside.

♪ TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · WHERE DO YOU LIVE? chorus → Tuesday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Where do you live? Where do you **F** live? **C** (*open hands, questioning*)

F Tell me, **C** tell me, where do you **G7** live? **C** (*cup your ear and lean in*)

C Every animal **F** has a **C** home, (*roof over your head with both hands*)

F A little **C** home to **G7** call their **C** own! (*hug yourself*)

TUESDAY · NEST & DEN (THE LONG ONE — TWO HOMES)

C The bird lives up in a cosy nest, (*cupped nest hands, lifted high*)

G7 Twigs and moss — **C** she likes it best! (*pat the rim of the nest*)

C The fox lives down in a dark, dark den, (*both hands into a low arch*)

G7 Sleeps all day **C** and comes out again! (*head on your hands, then pop out*)

The one song of the week — same chorus at every circle, one new verse each morning, the whole thing on Friday. This week's Tuesday verse is the **long** one, because Tuesday is carrying two homes. Chords and the full sheet are on the Song tab.

WEDNESDAY

The Jar Pond

Today's words: **pond** (*nest · den come back*)

Grab: a **jar pond** in the Magic Box — a big clear jar with water, a strand of pond weed and a model fish in it, screwed shut and carried flat; a shallow basin, paper fish with a paperclip on each nose, and a stick-and-string rod with a magnet on the end; a towel on the floor **before** the children sit down; the pond card.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today the box is **heavy**, and you carry it with two hands and a worried face. Whole class chants:

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Do **not** shake it. Tell them you can't. Tip it a few degrees instead — and something inside **sloshes**. Do it again. Let them hear it.

TEACHER "It's **wet**... it's got **weed** in it... and somebody in here is **swimming**." (*lift the jar out and hold it up to the window so the light comes through the water*)

The jar goes round the circle, held in two hands, and every child looks *through* it. One hand swimming like a fish: "**Pond!**"

4 MIN TEACH · POND

Everybody's hand becomes a fish. We say it twice — slow and deep, then quick:

Down in the water, cool and green, (*one hand swims down low, past your knees*)

The quietest home you've ever seen. (*finger on lips, eyes wide*)

No twigs, no moss, no door, no bed — (*shake your head at each one*)

Just **water** over the fish's head! (*flat hand passes right over your own head*)

Now the true thing, said slowly, with the jar in your hands: a nest is no good to a fish and a pond is no good to a bird. Hold the nest up beside the jar so they can see both at once. **The right home for the right animal** — that is the whole week in one picture.

LITTLES swim one hand and say "**Pond!**" **BIGS** owe you the frame: "**The fish lives in the pond.**" "**The fish does not live in a nest!**"

Teacher fails: take the little fox from yesterday's den and lower him, very carefully, into the jar. Look pleased. Hold it. Wait for the roar.

Chinese moment: the **pond** card joins nest and burrow on the mat — pond. Then one line of "The Tadpole Looks for His Mother": the little tadpole swimming round the pond asking everybody *Are you my mother?* One line only, then stop — the tadpole is looking for exactly what we are: the right home.

3 MIN GAME · MAGNET FISHING

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" The basin is the pond, the paper fish are floating in it, and there is one rod. Towel down first.

TEACHER "Fish for **one**... lift it out... and **tell us where it lives.**" (*hand the rod on to the next child, never fish twice yourself*)

Every catch is said out loud before it is put down: "**The fish lives in the pond.**" **LITTLES** hold the fish up and say "**Pond!**" — a full win. Everybody gets one turn; the ones waiting count the catches out loud.

One rod, one turn, and the rest of the class watching is the point — this game is really a lesson in waiting, and the fishing is the sugar. If the water goes everywhere, that is what the towel is for; do not stop the game to mop.

1 MIN CLOSE

Everybody's hand swimming. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Where do you live? — **HOME!**" (*open hands questioning · cup the ear · both arms thrown wide into a roof on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? Leave the jar pond on the window sill and look at it again at the end of the day. Ask what has moved. Something always has.

♪ **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · WHERE DO YOU LIVE?** chorus → Wednesday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Where do you live? Where do you **F** live? **C** (*open hands, questioning*)

F Tell me, **C** tell me, where do you **G7** live? **C** (*cup your ear and lean in*)

C Every animal **F** has a **C** home, (*roof over your head with both hands*)

F A little **C** home to **G7** call their **C** own! (*hug yourself*)

WEDNESDAY · POND

C The fish lives deep in the cool, cool pond, (*one hand swims down low*)

G7 Swish, swish, swish — **C** he swims along! (*swim the hand right across*)

Sing this verse *low* — drop your voice as the hand goes down, and come back up bright for the chorus. Yesterday's nest-and-den verse comes back too if you have the breath; two verses and a chorus is still only three minutes.

THURSDAY

A Silky Web

Today's words: **web** (*nest · den · pond come back*)

Grab: a **wool web** in the Magic Box — white wool wound across a bent wire hoop or a forked stick, with a small **spider** sitting in the middle of it; one big **ball of wool** for the circle game (a whole ball, not a scrap); a water spray bottle; the web card.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today the box makes no sound at all, however hard you shake it. Whole class chants:

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Shake — nothing. Shake harder — still nothing. Sniff — nothing. Now lift the lid and go completely still.

TEACHER "It's so **light**... it's made of **string**... and it was made by somebody with **eight legs**." (*lift the hoop out by its edges and hold it up against the light; then spray it once, and it glitters*)

The web goes round the circle held by the frame, never touched in the middle. Ten fingers spread wide: **"Web!"**

4 MIN TEACH · WEB

Ten fingers up, spread as wide as they will go. Twice — slowly, then fast:

Round and round and round I go, (*wind one finger round and round*)

Out of my **body** the silk does grow! (*pull an invisible thread out of your tummy*)

Sticky and shiny and strong as string, (*pinch and stretch the thread between two hands*)

My house is a **web** — and I made the thing! (*ten fingers wide, very proud*)

Then the plain true thing: the bird **collected** her nest, the fox **dug** his den — but the spider makes her whole house **out of herself**, in one night, and if it breaks she makes another one. Say it once. Let it sit there.

LITTLES spread ten fingers and say **"Web!"** **BIGS** owe you the frame: **"The spider lives in a web."** **"The spider made her own home."**

Teacher fails: announce that you will now make a web, out of yourself, exactly like a spider. Strain. Go red. Produce nothing whatsoever. Ask them, wounded, what you are doing wrong.

Chinese moment: the **web** card joins the row — spider's web. Four cards now: nest · burrow · pond · web, and tomorrow the fifth one finishes it. Say all four together, pointing, quickly.

3 MIN GAME · WEAVE THE WEB

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Everybody sits in a circle, cross-legged, knees nearly touching. You hold the ball of wool.

TEACHER (*hold the end of the wool tightly*) "I'm sending it to... **Mei**. Hold your thread and **don't let go**. Now Mei sends it to somebody else."

The ball rolls across the circle, child to child, each one keeping hold of their bit. Say the name every time. Slowly the whole class becomes one enormous web, and then everybody **lifts it together**, gently, off the floor. Look at it. Bounce the spider on it if you have a light one.

LITTLES just hold their thread and say **"Web!"** **BIGS** say who they are sending it to: **"I send my thread to Leo."**

Wind the ball back up together at the end, child by child, in reverse — it takes one extra minute and it is the calmest minute of the day. Do not cut the wool.

1 MIN CLOSE

Everybody's ten fingers spread wide. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Where do you live? — HOME!" (*open hands questioning · cup the ear · both arms thrown wide into a roof on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *The Very Busy Spider* (Eric Carle) — every animal asks her to come and play and she just keeps building. It is the same lesson as the whole week and they can feel the web on the page.

» TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · WHERE DO YOU LIVE? chorus → Thursday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Where do you live? Where do you **F** live? **C** (*open hands, questioning*)

F Tell me, **C** tell me, where do you **G7** live? **C** (*cup your ear and lean in*)

C Every animal **F** has a **C** home, (*roof over your head with both hands*)

F A little **C** home to **G7** call their **C** own! (*hug yourself*)

THURSDAY · WEB

C The spider sits on a silky web, (*ten fingers spread wide, very still*)

G7 Round and round **C** on a silver thread! (*wind one finger round and round*)

Sing this one almost still — only the winding finger moves — and then explode back into the chorus. Tomorrow the whole song goes top to bottom, so tell them that today: *four verses, and tomorrow we sing all of them*.

FRIDAY

Where Do You Live? + Big Review

Today's words: **live** — and **nest · den · pond · web**, the whole week

Grab: everything from the week packed back into the box — the nest, the den, the jar pond, the wool web — plus a **basket of small animal figures** (bird, fox, fish, spider, bee, and two or three more); the awards (print pack page 17); the home card. Next week is **The Earth**.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

The box comes out bulging and will not quite shut.

TEACHER "Today the box is FULL — it's got everybody's **HOUSE** inside it!"

Pull each home out and stand it on the mat in silence. They will supply the word before you can.

The nest → **"Nest!"** The shoebox → **"Den!"** The jar → **"Pond!"** The hoop → **"Web!"**

Four homes in a row on the mat. Then tip the basket of animals out in the middle, in a heap. Nobody lives anywhere yet.

4 MIN TEACH • LIVE, THEN THE WHOLE WEEK

Everybody stands. We tell the whole week with our bodies, twice — slow, then fast:

The bird lives in a **nest**, (*cup both hands into a bowl, lifted high*)

The fox lives in a **den**, (*both hands into a low arch*)

The fish lives in the **pond**, (*one hand swims down low*)

The spider in her **web** — (*ten fingers spread wide*)

And I live in my **HOME!** (*both arms up into a big roof over your own head*)

Then, one at a time, round the circle: every child picks one animal out of the heap and walks it to the home it belongs in. Nobody is corrected out loud — if it goes in the wrong place, ask the **class**: "Is the fish happy in there?"

LITTLES carry the animal and say the one word: **"Pond!"** **BIGS** owe you the whole sentence as they set it down: **"The fish lives in the pond."** Then the last question, to every single child by name: **"Where do you live?"**

Teacher fails: pick up the spider and announce that she is going to live in the jar pond from now on, because it is nicer. Start unscrewing the lid. Wait.

Chinese moment: the **home** card finishes the row — nest · burrow · pond · web · **home**. home is the one that matters: *home*. Point at each child and say **my home**, and let them say it back. Then tell them the whole row is going up on the wall.

3 MIN GAME • WHO LIVES HERE?

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Quick-fire, and fast is the whole point. You hold up one animal; they shout the home. Then you hold up one home; they shout the animal.

TEACHER "Bird!" → **"NEST!"** "Fox!" → **"DEN!"** "Fish!" → **"POND!"** "Spider!" → **"WEB!"** "Bee!" → **"HIVE!"**

Then throw in one wrong one on purpose — hold up the fish and say "nest?" with a hopeful face — and let them shout you down.

Finish on the one that is not a trick: **"Where do you live?"** and every child gets to answer, in any language, in any number of words.

Keep it under two minutes. The moment it slows down, stop it and do the awards — a quick-fire that outstays its welcome loses everything it just proved.

1 MIN CLOSE + AWARDS

Every child gets a "You are a STAR!" award to take home with the wrap-up. Then, standing round the four homes with the animals all in their right places:

EVERYONE "Where do you live? — HOME!" (*open hands questioning · cup the ear · both arms thrown wide into a roof on the shout, as loud as it has been all week*)

Got 3 spare minutes? Leave the four homes out over the weekend and tell them the nest stays up in the classroom all month. Next week is **The Earth** — the biggest home of the lot, and it is the one everybody in this room shares.

♪ **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT • WHERE DO YOU LIVE?** Friday's verse, then the **WHOLE** song, top to bottom

CHORUS

C Where do you live? Where do you **F** live? **C** (*open hands, questioning*)

F Tell me, **C** tell me, where do you **G7** live? **C** (*cup your ear and lean in*)

C Every animal **F** has a **C** home, (*roof over your head with both hands*)

F A little **C** home to **G7** call their **C** own! (*hug yourself*)

FRIDAY • LIVE

C Bird and fox and fish and me — (*point round the circle, then at yourself*)

G7 Everybody **C** has a home, you see! (*big roof over your head*)

The finale: chorus → Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, Friday → chorus, standing round the four homes with every animal in its right place. Four verses, learned one a morning without anybody noticing, and this run-through **is** the review of the whole week.

★ Where Do You Live?

Week 28 theme song
C (0003) · F (2010) · G7 (0212)

The one song of the week — sung at every circle. Same chorus daily, one new verse each morning, full song on Friday.

CHORUS — SING IT EVERY SINGLE DAY

- C** Where do you live? Where do you **F** live? **C** *(open hands, questioning)*
F Tell me, **C** tell me, where do you **G7** live? **C** *(cup your ear and lean in)*
C Every animal **F** has a **C** home, *(roof over your head with both hands)*
F A little **C** home to **G7** call their **C** own! *(hug yourself)*

TUESDAY · NEST & DEN (THE LONG ONE — TWO HOMES)

- C** The bird lives up in a cosy nest, *(cupped nest hands, lifted high)*
G7 Twigs and moss — **C** she likes it best! *(pat the rim of the nest)*
C The fox lives down in a dark, dark den, *(both hands into a low arch)*
G7 Sleeps all day **C** and comes out again! *(head on your hands, then pop out)*

WEDNESDAY · POND

- C** The fish lives deep in the cool, cool pond, *(one hand swims down low)*
G7 Swish, swish, swish — **C** he swims along! *(swim the hand right across)*

THURSDAY · WEB

- C** The spider sits on a silky web, *(ten fingers spread wide, very still)*
G7 Round and round **C** on a silver thread! *(wind one finger round and round)*

FRIDAY · LIVE

- C** Bird and fox and fish and me — *(point round the circle, then at yourself)*
G7 Everybody **C** has a home, you see! *(big roof over your head)*

Strum: Down · Down · Down-Up (“where — do — you-live”).

Can't manage it yet? Four slow downs per bar works fine — it is a question-and-answer song and the children are listening to the question.

Practice this loop for five minutes tonight: **C** (4 strums) → **F** (4 strums) → **C** → **G7** → **C**. That is the entire chorus, and the whole song is those three shapes — there is no Am this week at all. C is one finger, F is two, G7 is three; learn them in that order. If your fingers get stuck, put the uke down, hold the nest up in both hands and do the finger-play instead: the class will not notice, and the actions carry the meaning either way.